

# Project Gutenberg language diversity over time

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## Abstract

## 1 Introduction

This study analyses the linguistic diversity in Project Gutenberg's digital library collection over time, examining changes in the additions for each language in the Gutenberg Collection per year. The research aims to understand how increased internet access in non-English speaking countries may have influenced digital preservation efforts. It does this by

## 2 Related Work

Several studies have examined linguistic diversity in digital libraries and Project Gutenberg specifically:

[1] explored multilingualism on the web and Project Gutenberg's early efforts at linguistic diversification, providing important historical context for understanding the evolution of digital preservation efforts.

2. Gerlach, M., & Font-Clos, F. (2020) analysed a curated Project Gutenberg database, revealing a strong bias toward Western languages, with English comprising 81% of all books. Their work established baseline metrics for understanding linguistic representation in digital libraries.

## 3 Data

**Pre-processing** The data pre-processing was done by downloading the metadata of all Project Gutenberg books. This data can be downloaded in the form of a CSV file, which contains the relevant fields for this article: the date added and the language. Books that included multiple languages, either due to being a translation that includes the original text or being a translation dictionary, are counted for both languages. The python script

used for processing the data will be included with the paper. Due to not being completed, the year 2025 was excluded from this data.

## 4 Predicted Results

We expect that the data will show an increase in the proportion of non-English books in Project Gutenberg's collection over time. This is based on the idea that increased internet access in non-English speaking countries leads to greater easier access and participation with Project Gutenberg. Additionally, we anticipate that the diversity of languages represented will have broadened, reflecting a more globalized effort in digital preservation.

## Discussion

## 5 Conclusion

## References

- [1] Richard J. Whitt. *Diachronic Corpora, Genre, and Language Change*. Amsterdam/Philadelphia, NETHERLANDS, THE: John Benjamins Publishing Company, 2018. ISBN: 978-90-272-6350-6. URL: <http://ebookcentral.proquest.com/lib/rug/detail.action?docID=6733930> (visited on 12/05/2024).